

WHILE I WAS MUSING THE FIRE BURNED

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Psalm 143:1-6 (NKJV) *“A Psalm of David. Hear my prayer, O Lord, Give ear to my supplications! In Your faithfulness answer me, And in Your righteousness. 2 Do not enter into judgment with Your servant, For in Your sight no one living is righteous. 3 For the enemy has persecuted my soul; He has crushed my life to the ground; He has made me dwell in darkness, Like those who have long been dead. 4 Therefore my spirit is overwhelmed within me; My heart within me is distressed. 5 I remember the days of old; I meditate on all Your works; I muse on the work of Your hands. 6 I spread out my hands to You; My soul longs for You like a thirsty land. Selah.”*

Psalms 39:1-3 (NKJV) ***“To the Chief Musician. To Jeduthun. A Psalm of David. I said, “I will guard my ways, Lest I sin with my tongue; I will restrain my mouth with a muzzle, While the wicked are before me.” 2 I was mute with silence, I held my peace even from good; And my sorrow was stirred up. 3 My heart was hot within me; While I was musing, the fire burned. Then I spoke with my tongue.”***

INTRO: There are two things in our text that I want to zero in on:

- Musing
- Fire

Let’s look first at the word musing – When the Lord began to deal with me about this subject I had a most difficult time zeroing in

on what He wanted to communicate from these scriptures. After some intense meditation and research it became abundantly clear what the Holy Spirit was attempting to say to us through these passages of Scripture. Only three times in the Word of God is the word musing or some form of it used.

David used the words musing and muse once each in both of these texts, and then the word mused is used in Luke's Gospel concerning the people wondering if John the Baptist was actually the messiah.

The word muse means to be in a state of deep thought about a particular subject, and to be so focused on the subject that you are almost

in a trance. Musing can also find its expression in actually verbalizing those thoughts to oneself. (Talking to yourself) I think the latter is probably the case here with the Psalmist, and the reason I believe that is because he was so good at expressing himself with words and he often talked to Himself in an effort to ***“Encourage himself in the Lord.”***

The word fire refers to our passions. When we are passionate about a thing, we are excited about the prospect of the outcome. When the fire goes out in our lives, there is no excitement and therefore we usually do a lousy job! We deserve better than a passionless service and God certainly deserves better!

THE NEED FOR MUSING IS PERCIPITATED BY DISCOURAGEMENT AND DEFEAT...

Notice what David says in the first four verses of [Psalm 143:3-4](#) (NKJV) *“For the enemy has persecuted my soul; He has crushed my life to the ground; He has made me dwell in darkness, Like those who have long been dead. 4 Therefore my spirit is overwhelmed within me; My heart within me is distressed.”*

Take a look at the words David used to describe his condition:

- Persecuted...
- Crushed...
- Darkness...
- Dead...
- Overwhelmed...
- Distressed...

There is a better than good chance that David is dealing with some pretty significant depression here! He has reached rock bottom and does not appear to know how to reverse his condition! (Man in cemetery)

Though David has experienced some exhilarating victories in his lifetime, he also experienced some very difficult defeats. David was very well acquainted with the agony of defeat.

It is not uncommon for people who have experienced great victories to also have experienced more than their fair share of defeats:

- Henry Ford – Ford started five businesses that left him broke each time, before starting Ford Motor Company!
- R.H. Macy - Macy started seven failed businesses before finally hitting big with his store in New York City.
- Harlan David Sanders - Colonel Sanders of Kentucky Fried Chicken had a hard time selling his chicken at first. In fact, his famous secret chicken recipe was rejected 1,009 times before a restaurant accepted it.
- Bill Gates – Gates dropped out of Harvard and starting a failed first business with Microsoft co-founder Paul Allen, called Traf-O-Data. While this early idea didn't work, Gates' later work did, creating the global empire that is Microsoft.

- Walt Disney – Disney was fired by a newspaper editor because *"he lacked imagination and had no good ideas."* After that, Disney started a number of businesses that didn't last too long and ended with bankruptcy and failure. He kept plugging along and eventually found a recipe for success that worked.
- Abraham Lincoln – Lincoln went to war a captain and returned a private. He started several failed businesses and was defeated in numerous elections before being elected President of the United States of America.
- Winston Churchill - Churchill struggled in school and failed the sixth grade. After school he faced many years of political failures, as he was defeated in every bid for public office, until he finally became the Prime Minister at the ripe old age of

62. He was twice elected Prime Minister and won the Nobel Peace Prize!

- Thomas Edison – Edison was told by his teachers he was *"too stupid to learn anything."* He was fired from his first two jobs for not being productive enough. Edison made 1,000 unsuccessful attempts at inventing the light bulb. Of course, all those unsuccessful attempts finally resulted in the design that worked. When asked about his 1,000 failures he said, *"The light bulb has 1,000 steps of development."*
- Orville and Wilbur Wright - These brothers battled depression and family illness before starting the bicycle shop that would lead them to experimenting with flight. After numerous attempts at creating flying machines, several years of hard work, and tons of failed prototypes,

the brothers finally created a plane that could get airborne and stay there.

As we all do, David knew the excitement of victory and the depression of defeat but notice what he says in [Psalms 143:5](#) (NKJV) ***“I remember the days of old; I meditate on all Your works; I muse on the work of Your hands.”***

MUSING CAN CHANGE THE OUTCOME OF THE BATTLE...

I don't think anyone could say for sure, whether David was in deep thought about the works of God here, or he was talking out loud to himself about God's ability and willingness to deliver. All we can say with certainty is that his musing moved him from a defeatist

attitude to an attitude of victory! Look at how he starts [Psalm 144:1-2](#) (NKJV) “*Blessed be the Lord my Rock, Who trains my hands for war, And my fingers for battle-- 2 My lovingkindness and my fortress, My high tower and my deliverer, My shield and the One in whom I take refuge, Who subdues my people under me.*” David is proof that musing can snatch victory right out of the jaws of defeat!

[Psalm 39:3](#) (NKJV) “*My heart was hot within me; While I was musing, the fire burned.*”

The fire spoken of here is our passions! What those of us who are having a hard time maintaining a proper attitude of victory need to do, is a little more musing!

David was no stranger to the world of musing. In 1 Samuel 17 David's three older

brothers, Eliab, Abinadab, and Shammah are on the front lines of the battle facing the Giant Goliath! David goes to the front lines of the battle to bring some supplies to his brothers and to report back to Jesse about their well-being.

When he gets to where the battle was supposed to be going on he found something he did not expect to find. For the first time in his life David sees his brothers for what they really were, cowards!

Notice what David does, [1 Samuel 17:26-27](#) (NKJV) ***"Then David spoke to the men who stood by him, saying, 'What shall be done for the man who kills this Philistine and takes away the reproach from Israel? For who is this uncircumcised Philistine, that he should defy***

the armies of the living God?" 27 And the people answered him in this manner, saying, "So shall it be done for the man who kills him." (Old maids prayer – "Send me a man that we may fight together...")

Notice the kind of encouragement his brothers offered on his behalf, 1 Samuel 17:28 (NKJV) *"Now Eliab his oldest brother heard when he spoke to the men; and Eliab's anger was aroused against David, and he said, "Why did you come down here? And with whom have you left those few sheep in the wilderness? I know your pride and the insolence of your heart, for you have come down to see the battle."* I think David began to muse to himself here. He probably began to think about what his mom and dad had taught him concerning the god of Abraham,

and how He would fight for Israel. I believe he began to think about the prophet Samuel coming to the house of Jesse, and his dad calling him from the field, and the prophet taking that rams horn and pouring the oil over his head. If you've ever been anointed, you will never be the same. The anointing will make you feel:

- You can sell ice to an Eskimo...
- You can go bear hunting with a switch...
- You can lift the weight of the world on your shoulders...
- You can rake stars out of the sky with your bare hands...
- You can fly without the assistance of an aircraft...
- You can charge hell with a water pistol...

David can no longer keep quiet, he again inquires as to how to go about enlisting for the responsibility of killing the giant!

Saul finds out about his willingness, and sends some men to retrieve him. Remember, David is standing before Saul as a teenager! His words before the King are stunning! [1 Samuel 17:32](#) (NKJV) ***"Then David said to Saul, 'Let no man's heart fail because of him; your servant will go and fight with this Philistine.'"***

Notice what Saul says, [1 Samuel 17:33](#) (NKJV) ***"And Saul said to David, 'You are not able to go against this Philistine to fight with him; for you are a youth, and he a man of war from his youth.'"*** Really? Saul doesn't have one stinking man in his army willing to fight Goliath, including himself, and now he is

attempting to discourage David! Notice what David does here, right before God, Saul, his yellow belly brothers, the terrified troops, and everybody else! He begins to muse, and listen to what he says, [1 Samuel 17:34-37](#) (NKJV) *"But David said to Saul, "Your servant used to keep his father's sheep, and when a lion or a bear came and took a lamb out of the flock, 35 I went out after it and struck it, and delivered the lamb from its mouth; and when it arose against me, I caught it by its beard, and struck and killed it. 36 Your servant has killed both lion and bear; and this uncircumcised Philistine will be like one of them, seeing he has defied the armies of the living God." 37 Moreover David said, "The Lord, who delivered me from the paw of the lion and from the paw of the bear, He will deliver me from the hand of this Philistine." And Saul said to David, "Go, and the Lord be with you!"*

Notice what David does in preparing for the battle! [1 Samuel 17:40-51](#) (NKJV) *"Then he took his staff in his hand; and he chose for himself five smooth stones from the brook, and put them in a shepherd's bag, in a pouch which he had, and his sling was in his hand. And he drew near to the Philistine. 41 So the Philistine came, and began drawing near to David, and the man who bore the shield went before him. 42 And when the Philistine looked about and saw David, he disdained him; for he was only a youth, ruddy and good-looking. 43 So the Philistine said to David, "Am I a dog, that you come to me with sticks?" And the Philistine cursed David by his gods. 44 And the Philistine said to David, "Come to me, and I will give your flesh to the birds of the air and the beasts of the field!" 45 Then David said to the Philistine, "You come to me with a sword,*

with a spear, and with a javelin. But I come to
you in the name of the Lord of hosts, the God
of the armies of Israel, whom you have defied.
46 This day the Lord will deliver you into my
hand, and I will strike you and take your head
from you. And this day I will give the carcasses
of the camp of the Philistines to the birds of
the air and the wild beasts of the earth, that all
the earth may know that there is a God in
Israel. 47 Then all this assembly shall know
that the Lord does not save with sword and
spear; for the battle is the Lord's, and He will
give you into our hands." 48 So it was, when
the Philistine arose and came and drew near to
meet David, that David hastened and ran
toward the army to meet the Philistine. 49
Then David put his hand in his bag and took
out a stone; and he slung it and struck the
Philistine in his forehead, so that the stone
sank into his forehead, and he fell on his face

to the earth. 50 So David prevailed over the Philistine with a sling and a stone, and struck the Philistine and killed him. But there was no sword in the hand of David. 51 Therefore David ran and stood over the Philistine, took his sword and drew it out of its sheath and killed him, and cut off his head with it. And when the Philistines saw that their champion was dead, they fled.” David was not saying this as much for the giants benefit as he was for his own! Sometime one must encourage his/herself in the Lord!

One cannot muse on the works of God without the fire burning! When David came dragging the bloody giants head down the hill, Saul said, *“Whose son is this?”* In other words, what kind of daddy can raise a boy like this? The difference between David and

his cowardly brothers is that David focused on the God of the battle while his brothers focused on the giant of the battle! What are we going to focus on?

THE DECISION RESTS WITH THE INDIVIDUAL: MUSE OR MUTTER, WHICH IS IT GOING TO BE?

The church seems to be long on figureheads, deadheads, meatheads and hotheads; what we really need is some people that will muse on the goodness of God until a passionate fire for the things of God begins to burn again!

Once the ashes of the past are stirred and the fire begins to flicker and burn, don't stop! It is at this juncture that we need to fan the flame with faith until God's glory floods our

lives, and the church again! How do we fan the flame with faith? By musing on the miracles God has performed in days gone by!

- My Dad injured in a logging accident when I was four...
- Living through poverty as a child and young adult...
- Being too broke to pay attention in 1980 - \$5,000.00 gross income...
- Walking through an intense ministry struggle in 1985...
- Bad news from the cardiologist in 2001...

Looking back I just have to shout, look what the Lord has done!

Because the Lord is more interested in developing character within than providing

comfortable surroundings, we will face times of intense struggle! Please know that before the battle was joined a strategy for victory was initiated!

The design of God is not intent on returning us to a former place of victory but to take us to a brand new level and do a new thing in our lives. This cannot occur without a struggle! Going back to a previous place of victory is:

- Dead in faith...
- Cul-de-sac faith...

The purpose of God is to take us *“From faith to faith and from victory to victory.”* That sounds wonderful, but sandwiched between faith and faith is a blue ribbon trial! Between

victory and victory is a battle-royal! So how do we get from faith to faith and from victory to victory? By musing on the benefits, blessings and favor of the Lord in our lives until we have the courage of a bulldog and the backbone of a saw-log!

As we muse on the work of His hands the fire of God and the wind of God will collide over the ash heap of our broken dreams, and new life springs forth! When this occurs there will be no more sifting through the ashes of the past, God will do a new thing!

PLACES PREACHED:

1st A/G Fouke AR 3/13/97

1st A/G Malvern AR 3/16/97 Camp Meeting

1st A/G Forest City AR 4/11/97 Fellowship Meeting

Northern Manitoba Family Camp Thompson Canada 6/29/97

Mountain Valley Retreat Center Hot Springs AR –

Conway 1st A/G Family Camp 8/97

Harvestime A/G Murfreesboro AR Fellowship Meeting 4/16/98

1st A/G Russellville AR 8/23/98 AM

1st A/G Jonesboro AR 10/28/98 Sectional Council

1st A/G Malvern AR Pastors Sharing Day 11/5/98

1st A/G Sheridan AR 6/9/99 Tent Revival

Sunnyside A/G Van Buren AR 6/28/99

1st A/G Camden AR 10/12/99 Sectional Fellowship Meeting

Sand Hill A/G Doddridge AR 5/27/01 Bobby
Stouts 20th Pastoral Anniversary

1st A/G Sturttgart AR 11/6/01

Trinity Temple A/G Arkadelphia AR 11/7/01

Greens Bayou A/G Houston TX 1/9/02

Missions Convention

CT Houston TX 12/1/02 AM

District Presbytery STXAG Houston TX

11/11/03

HCC Kerrville TX 9/05

Otter Creek A/G Little Rock AR 10/8/06

CT Church Houston TX 9/12/10 AM

1st A/G Neederland TX 9/12/10 PM

CT Houston 5/21/17 ½ sermon – Celebration
Sunday